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African women

Author(S): Leith-Ross, Sylvia, Lugard, Frederick John Dealtry, Baron

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IX Sophisticated-Primitive Woman—in Nguru

As one can imagine, this attitude created an atmosphere in which it was wellnigh impossible to get reliable information. Not one single subject would be touched on which would not be made to refer to tax or riots, whether it was interest in a baby's age or the colour of a woman's goats or the origin of a patient's toothache. Either I was secretly searching for the real leaders of the Riots or I was 'writing a report to give to my husband who would then come and tax the women'. How far this fear was sincere and how far it was put on out of love for the dramatic, out of the already-mentioned tendency to see the worst side of everything, out of the desire to feel [injured](#) so that there should be an added reason for self-pity, out of a child's trembling enjoyment of his self-induced terrors, was impossible to tell. They probably did not know themselves and their intelligence was still so limited that no one could help them to disentangle their motives. The very neutrality of my position was a stumbling-block: neither missionary nor trader, I *must* be Government. When crossing a crowded market-place, a woman rose up and shouted: 'Tell the white woman nothing. She has only come to harm us!' Again, walking back one evening with a band of women returning from their farms, chatting peaceably about crops and prices, one, evidently the *esprit fort* of the group, strode up beside me: 'You who are Government, tell us why the price of oil has fallen?' I explained once more I was not Government but it was no use. 'Tell us why Government does not give us money. Tell us why we are taxed. Tell us why Government starves us.' Voices got shrill. Excitement grew. 'Our children die. We ourselves die.' The women stopped in a serried group, with hostile looks and murmurs. 'Government kill me! See how thin I am!' and the speaker, momentary madness in her eyes, by some trick of posture turned herself into a living skeleton and threw herself into a wild war dance, two feet in front of me. Fortunately I was thin too, and by the time we had compared bones and knuckles, the women were laughing and the difficult moment was over. I

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would have thought they had just been trying it on, partly as a joke or to see whether they could get anything out of me but that glint of madness was real and I can only repeat the remark made in my diary: 'Queer creatures. All right when you have only a few of them, but thousands as in the Riots....'

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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